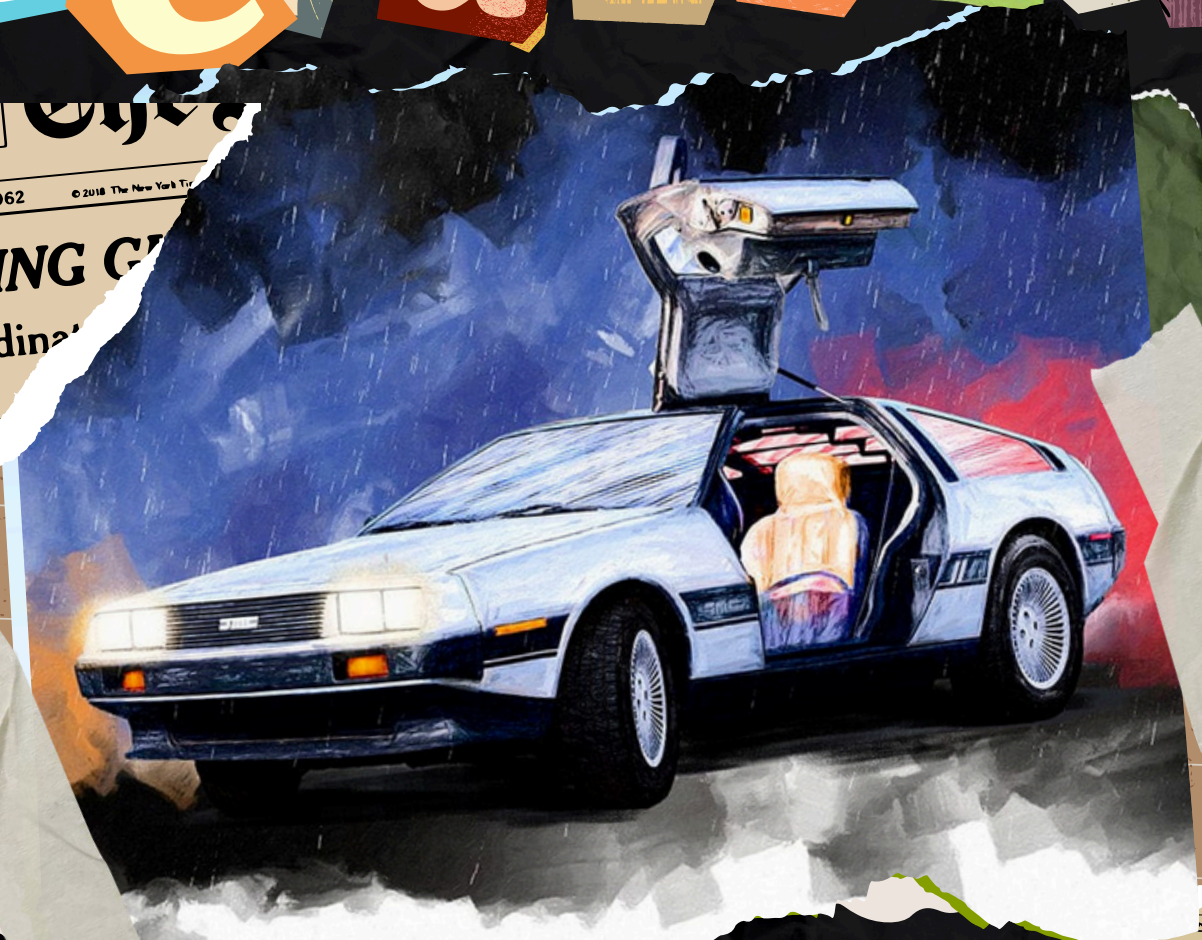
JAZZ LAB

Henrique Eisenmann and Tim Lienhard

Octatonic



THE SCALE OF THE FUTURE

JAZZ LAB

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THE OCTATONIC MAGIC





The octatonic scale is one the most interesting scales in music; it has been used in many different contexts over the past 130 years, especially in Modern Music from the 1940s and 50s. However, its sound is still fresh, relevant and magical to our 21st century years.

Traditional Jazz Theory looks at the octatonic scale as a dominant scale from with you can derive patterns and voicings. We prefer to treat it as a mode: a whole universe of its own, with gravity, center and unique colors. This is super helpful for composition, arrangements, introductions, improv sections, film-scoring, etc.

Let's dive in.

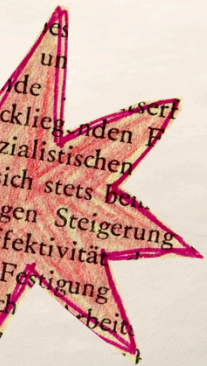
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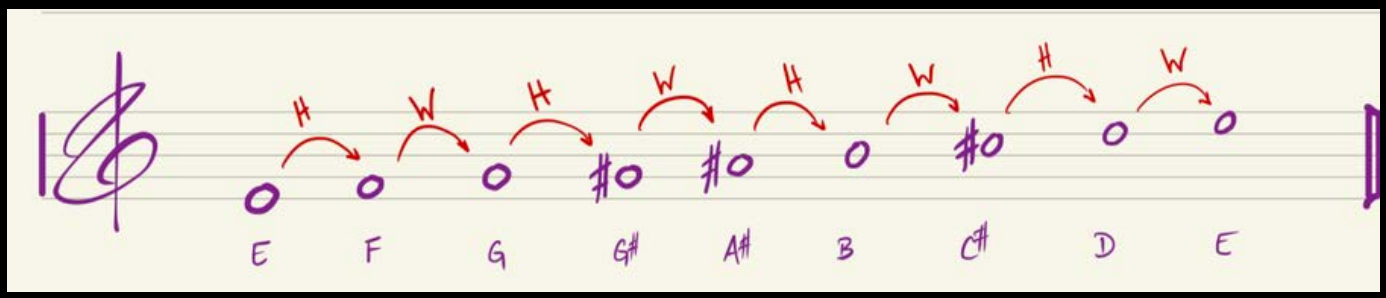




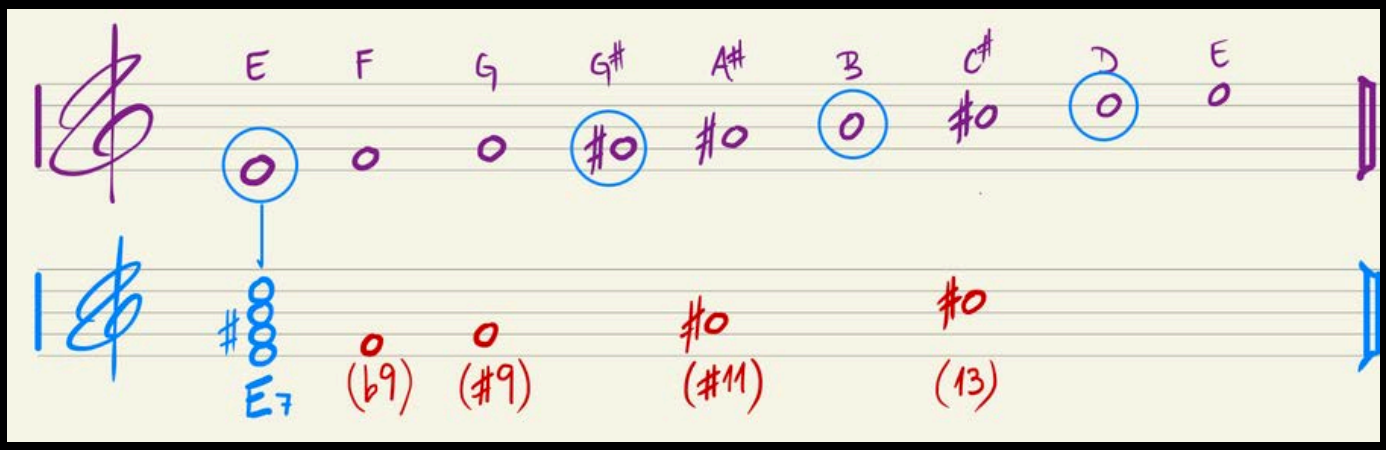


THE PRINCIPLE

The octatonic scale contains eight notes, and it looks very similar to the diminished scale, although it is not exactly the same. Once you choose your initial note you will move upwards half-step, whole-step, half-step, whole-step, half-step, whole-step.... and so on.



In traditional Jazz Theory, the octatonic scale is used over dominant chords, since it outlines a dominant chord and offers an interesting set of tensions.



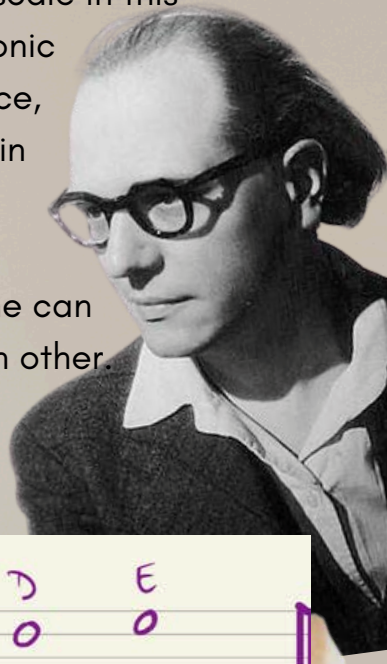
If you are unfamiliar with chord tensions, check out our video and e-Book on chord tensions and how they operate.

Pianists like Chick Corea utilize octatonic patterns all the time when addressing dominant chords. Our favorite use, however, is different than traditional Jazz.
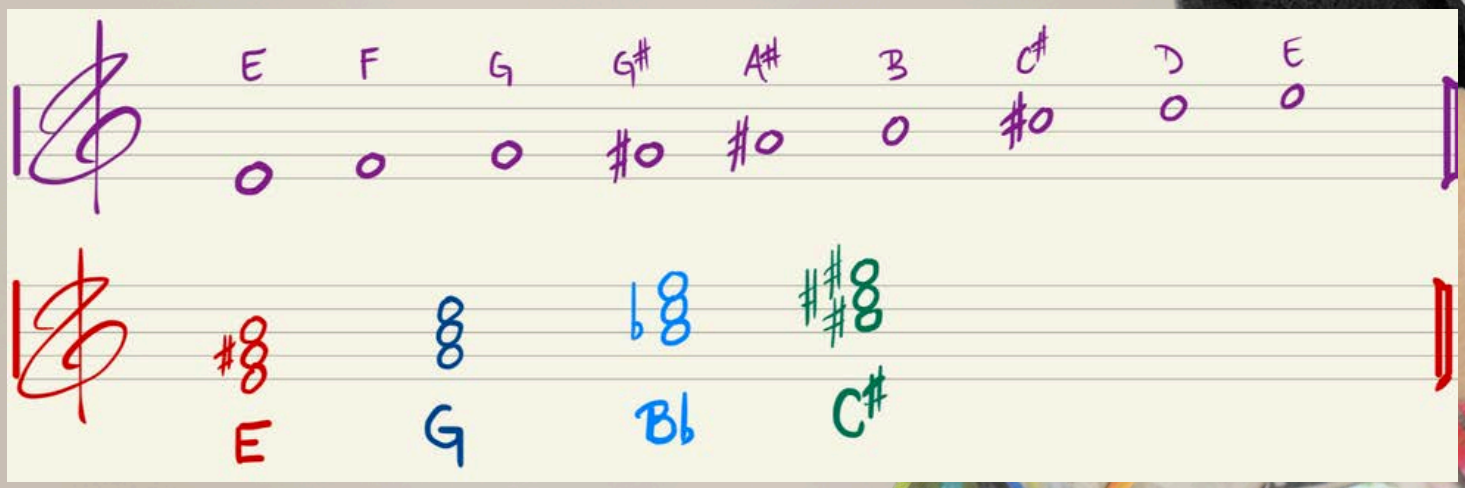


We prefer to explore the octatonic scale as mode, not as a scale. This means we like to stay longer in the octatonic scale, explore its different colors, dissonances, frictions. Treat it as a tonal center, with gravity, instead of a temporary dominant scale.
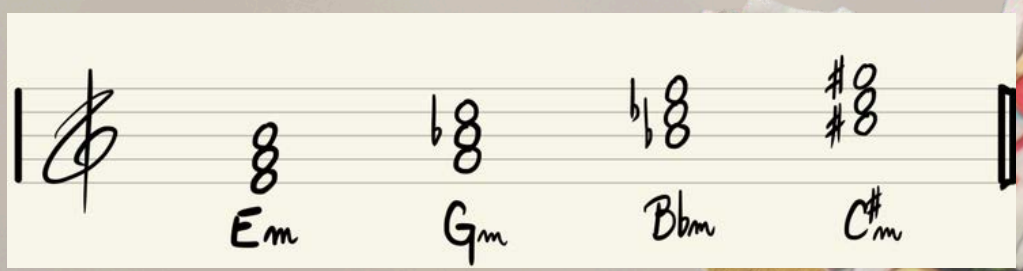
French composer Olivier Messiaen was famous for using the octatonic scale in this way. He has several pieces that are written exclusively inside the octatonic universe, such as many of his preludes and movements of his masterpiece, the "Quartet for the End of Time", written inside a concentration camp in 1941.



One of the most interesting properties of the Octatonic scale is that one can find FOUR different major chords, each one a minor 3rd apart from each other. This can offer many possibilities of unusual harmonic progressions.



Equally fascinating is the fact that you can also find four minor chords in the octatonic scale:

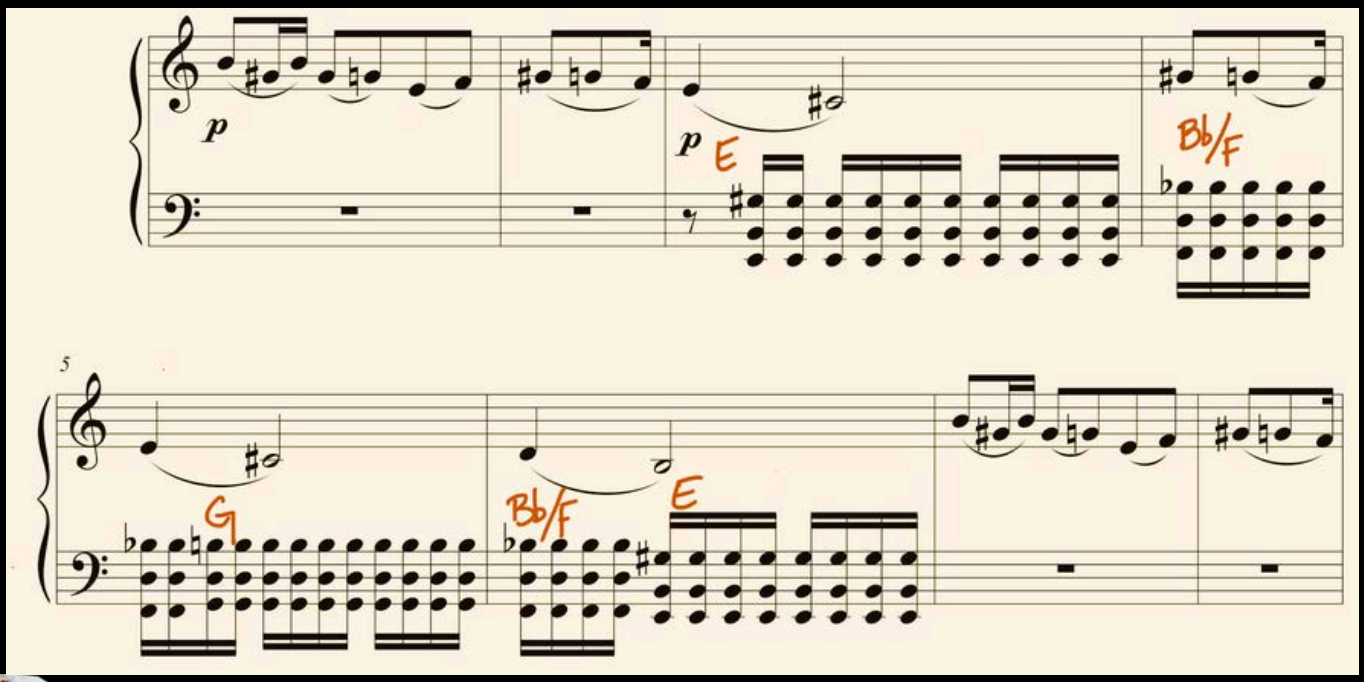


PLAYING OCTATONIC



Let's create a Messiaen inspired improvisation:

- Listen to the "Louange Pour L'eternité de Jesus", from Messiaen's masterpiece, the *Quartet for the End of Time*.
- Try identifying the moments in which the octatonic scales is outlined.
- In the excerpt below, notice how long Messiaen stays in each chord. All of the chords used are part of the octatonic scale.



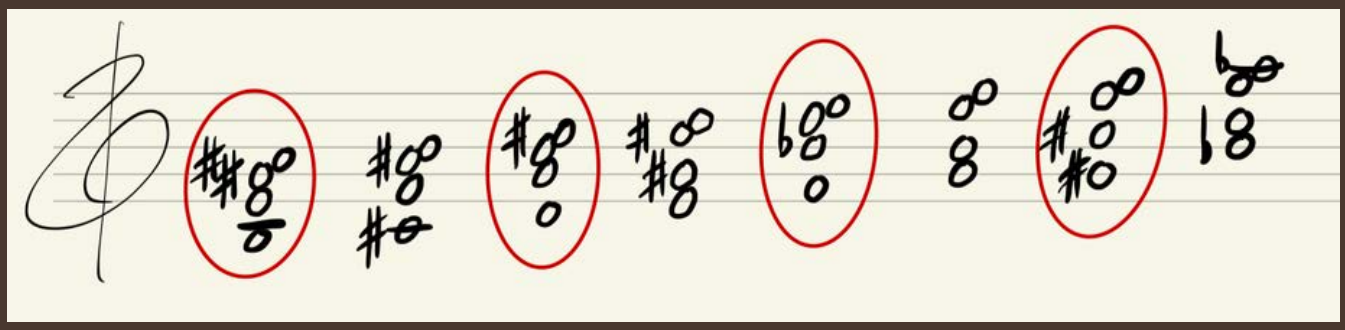


- Improvise in a similar style. You may use a drone, or play it with a friend; Only exclusively chords and melody from the octatonic scale.
- Savor each note of the octatonic scale and how it relates to the chord. Some notes may feel dissonant, but after some time they start to feel truly delicious to the ear. Improvise slowly.
- Repeat the chords in pulses, several times, before changing to the next chord (E, G, Bb and C#). Feel free to invert chords, but refrain from adding tensions. These chords work best when bare.

OTHER SUGGESTIONS



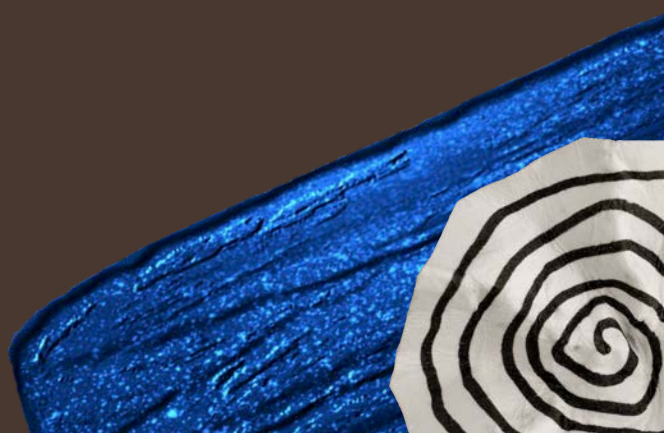
- Create a long introduction for a ballad in which you stay for a long time in the octatonic world, alternating the major chords slowly.
- Try improvising folk melodies in octatonic mode, in the style of Bartok.
- Create your unique octatonic chords: start with an unconventional voicing (combination of pitches) and then move this exact structure through the octatonic notes.



(these were some of Messiaen's favorite voicings)

- Pick famous melodies (famous tunes, soundtracks, folk songs, nursery songs) and play them exclusively with octatonic notes over a drone. The transformation is fascinating.
- Since the octatonic scale is full of internal symmetries, an octatonic melody starting on E, can also be played in G, Bb and C#, which can be an excellent way to create an ambiguous sounding melody, almost bi-tonal.
- There are only 3 possible modulations of the octatonic scale. After that it starts to repeat itself. So learn all the 3 options (I personally like to think of the octatonic starting on C, then on D and then on E).





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